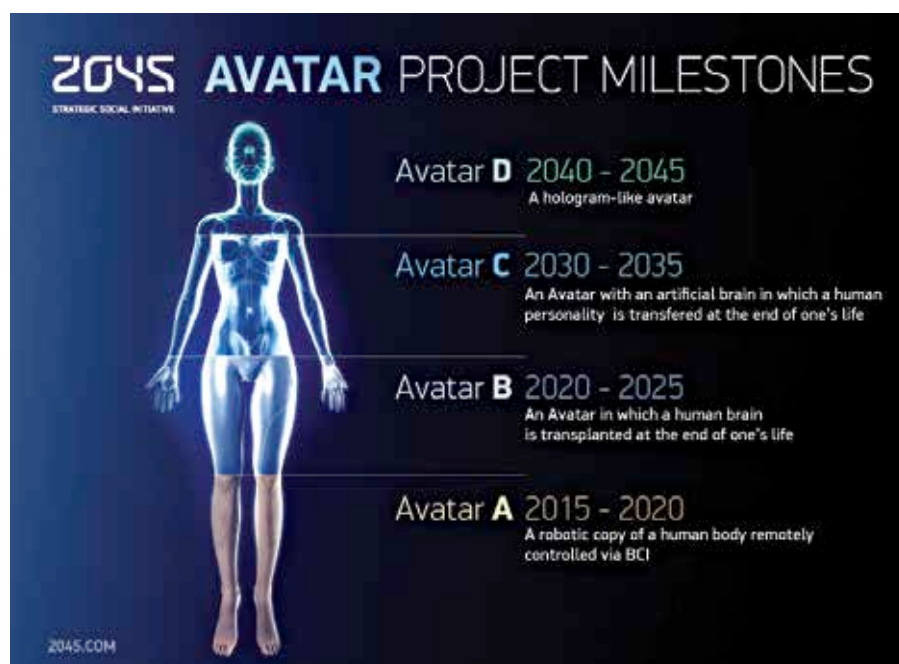


towards cybernetics immortality, where we create a neo-humanity and truly take control of our evolution beyond the grasp of nature's biosphere. And that, according to various schools of thoughts, is the only true way for us to become truly immortal. And the Avatar Project is the first major step in that direction.

The Avatar Project is the brainchild of Russian billionaire, Dmitry Itskov, who isn't unlike Peter Weyland from the movie *Prometheus* – both want to be immortal. While Weyland looked at the stars for answers, Itskov's putting his trust in neuroscientists, neuroengineers and futurists to allow him to "live" forever. Not just him, but everyone. Eventually.

The Avatar Project seeks to conquer death in four stages by 2045. Stage one deals with the creation of a robot that can be controlled by our brains (through a brain-machine interface) by 2020; Stage two takes things further when a human brain can be transplanted into a synthetic body by 2025; Stage three is where the boundaries between humans and robots blur, and it will be achieved after the contents of a person's brain can be uploaded into a synthetic one by 2035. The last and final stage of the project, slated to end by 2045, results with the completion of a full-blown Avatar, a hologram that will replace bodies completely and allow us humans to live forever.

This may sound like a hoax, but it actually isn't. Itskov's vision is backed not only by his own deep pockets but also other tech luminaries – Itskov's ambitious roadmap is supported by visionaries like roboticist Hiroshi Ishiguro, Google's director of engineering, Ray Kurzweil, and chairman of the X-Prize



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Foundation, Peter Diamandis. Even the Dalai Lama has given his blessings and endorsed Itskov's vision, when he said in a press release, "We should carry out these experiments with a full sense of responsibility and respect for life that will only benefit humanity, benefit others."

Ray Kurzweil, Google's director of engineering and a self-confessed futurist, said at a WSJ conference recently that "We're going to expand who we are. We're going to become more non-biological." Calling the human body a "software process," Kurzweil believes that in the future humanity will no longer be limited to its physical form and be able to upload our consciousness into a cloud and use nanobots to recreate our physical bodies at will. And as humans start becoming more like machines, AI advancements

will make machines increasingly more human. This convergence is what Kurzweil calls "singularity."

Food for thought

So we are trying to achieve immortality by slowing down biological aging of the human body, by supplementing the human body with fresh, new lab-grown organs, and ultimately escape the constraints of our physical cage – arguably the best piece of intelligent life form that evolution has produced to rule the earth with – and exist in the form of a digital entity for eternity. And from the looks of it, all this doesn't seem to be the stuff of sci-fi at all.

So the question we put to you is this: Excited or petrified? And how will you start preparing for your immortal life? 

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